



book like Ikigai can teach you a lot. I have read Alchemist many times,” he shares.

So, who have been the biggest inspirations for Manish Sharma? He answers, “My mom, dad, and dad’s elder brother.”

Manish’s mother is an intelligent lady who thinks much ahead of time, and is liberal, empowering, and characterful. She would give space yet draw guardrails and inculcate value systems rather than telling things directly. She is the lady behind the strong value systems that got inculcated in her children. It lets them still keep their heads stable, irrespective of what the environment is. “My mother is still the biggest inspiration for me,” he says proudly.

Cricket, life, leadership

Manish was 11 when India’s legendary Kapil Dev lifted the first cricket World Cup ever won by the country. While the moment was as inspiring for Manish as for every Indian, this was also the time when his family owned a TV set for the first time.

“We were trying our hands at many sports including swimming, tennis, billiards, table tennis, cricket, and a lot more. As it happens, cricket is a religion for almost everyone in the country. The year 1983 was the time when me and millions of other Indians found inspiration in cricket. It was also the time when TVs had started coming into the town I lived in,” recalls Manish.

Manish’s maternal uncle had an electronics showroom in Gwalior, and the man who drives Panasonic India today never missed a chance to visit the same and try his hands at selling electronics. The year 1983 was a time when consumer electronics like TVs had just started making their journey into towns like Gwalior.

“My *mamaji* used to be a leading retailer of electronic goods in Gwalior, and he was amongst the top few in the country. He was not just retailing

products from top consumer electronic brands but was also getting radios manufactured locally. I, on weekends, used to go to the showroom owned by him and try selling products like Murphy radios, Philips radios, Ahuja public address systems, and lots of other things,” he shares.

“I do remember the nostalgic moment when Kapil Dev took that memorable catch of Vivian Richards. The TVs back then were all about showing hazy pictures, but that moment become inspiration for millions of people like me. I picked up a coffee-table book, which had photos of the Indian cricket team and their World Cup moments,” he recalls.

The days following the 1983 World Cup were filled with Manish playing cricket. Manish does not refer to himself as a good player but says he was lucky as he was able to score for the teams he played with when it mattered the most.

And what’s playing all these sports has enabled Manish to do? “I am a jack of all trades and master of none. I can try my hand in almost any sport, but I am a master of none,” he says.

A look at his professional innings and one realises that the man who is chairman of Panasonic India and South Asia is actually a master of overseeing strategy planning and business development for Panasonic. A closer scrutiny and you will find that Manish has worked in front-end operations, headed R&D, has been the chief of marketing and sales, and has worked on business development.

To add cherry to the cake, he is a prolific writer, one who shares his experiences around leadership and a lot of other things on LinkedIn. He also has a Youtube channel named Duologues where he interacts with public figures around leadership



Manish Sharma playing cricket at Panasonic factory in Jhajjar, Haryana

lessons. His conversation skills, and skills that make him resonate with the majority, or the right target audience, have probably played a big role in what he has achieved today.

“Cricket is by far the sport that I love to follow the most. It has so many learnings. I have seen that people who have committed themselves to the game and respect the game have done extraordinary. Whereas no matter how committed one is towards the game, but does not respect the game, ends up doing ordinary things,” he says. The game of cricket, as he shares, teaches a lot of leadership and how one can react in tough times. He is of the view that a lot of people in India learn their first leadership lessons through the game of cricket.

“Every individual is a sum total of people around. I think this is one of the biggest learnings that come from the game of cricket. It takes one ball to take a wicket and one ball to lose or win a game. On the other hand, there are so many overs, and in test matches so many days available. Cricket has taught me that life is not a sprint, it is a marathon. Cricket teaches us when to live life like a marathon and when to live it like a sprint,” he shares.

He adds, “Cricket teaches you to adapt in accordance with changing times and situations. Life is like that, you cannot live life like a sprint. All